

Hazrat Dawood

During the discussion on Hazrat Shamweel  where we dealt with the battle between Taaloot and Jaaloot mention was made of Nabi Dawud . At that time he was a young man but in years to come he would grow to become one of Allah's chosen Messengers to Bani Israel for their guidance as well as a *khalifa* for their social structure as a nation. During the life of Hazrat Taaloot already and after his death the rule over Bani Israel came into Dawud (*Alaihis Salām*)'s hands.

The Nickname of Khalifa

In Bani Israel Nabi Dawud  is the first person to be a *Nabi* as well as a king on the throne. The Qur'ān mentions this special honour and speciality in the following manner:

- 1) "And Allah gave power and wisdom and taught him whatever He willed." (2:251)
- 2) "O Dawud, we did indeed make you a vicegerent on earth." (37:26)
- 3) "To each of them (Sulaymaan and Dawud) we gave judgement and knowledge." (21:79)

Among all the Prophets except for Hazrat Adam , Nabi Dawud  is the only one when the Qur'ān calls by the

name '*Khalifa*'. This nickname points directly at Allah's attribute quality of knowledge and power. It seems that for that purpose, there is no better word to describe him except the word '*Khalifa*'.

Nabi Dawud  executed himself in the service of bringing guidance to Bani Israel. And he also supervised their social life structure. His special qualities were:

- 1) In the field of eloquence in public speaking he was a very good speaker and used to speak in such a manner that every word and thought was well understood and in such a manner that it appeared in a very well constructed manner.
- 2) His judgements between truth and falsehood was such that it was a final judgement on the issue.

The Zabbur

The Qur'ān states:

1. "And to Dawud we gave the Zabbur" (the psalms).
(4:163)
2. "We did bestow upon some Prophets more gifts than on other: And we gave to Dawud (the gift of) the Zabbur (the psalms).
(17:55)

Allah revealed the Zabbur to Nabi Dawud  which is such an anthology of words in which Allah is praised and thanked and in which the humility and servitude of men are admitted and recognised. In these verses of the Zabbur there are also valuable advices and admonitions. But like they did with the Torah and Injeel, Bani Israel also changed the wordings of the Zabbur, knowingly. The Qur'ān states:

"Of the Jews are those who displace words (of the Torah, Injeel, Zabbur) from their right places."
(5:14)

Special Qualities of Dawud ﷺ

In actual fact Allah had granted special honour and rank to all Prophets and bestowed numerous favours on all His Prophets and Messengers. But in the granting of special qualities. He has made various ranks for them, one above the other. These are the ranks by which some are superior to others.

"Those apostles we endowed with gifts, some above others."
(2:253)

In this manner the mentions some specialities of Nabi Dawud ﷺ in which respect he is superior to others: These are as follows:

Nabi Dawud ﷺ and Glorification of Allah

Hazrat Dawud ﷺ used to busy himself much with glorifying Allah and praising His Name. In this he had such a melodious voice that not only did men who heard him fall into an ecstatic trance, but also the animals and birds became so affected. They used to then gather around him, singing Allah's praises together with him. At the same time the mountains too echoed with the praises. Allah mentions this in *Surah Ambiya*, *Surah Saba'* and *Surah Saud*.

"Have patience at what they say and remember our servant Dawud.

The man of strength. For he ever turned to Allah.

It was we that made the hills declare in unison
with him our praises at eventide and at break of
day." (37:16—19)

Some *Mufasssireen* of the Qur'ān wrote on these verses that the *Tasbeeh* of the animals and birds and the mountains used to declare silently in their manner that everything in this universe and their forms and every atom in them bear witness to the existence of their creator. This was their *Tasbeeh*.

In contrast to that interpretation the research scholars declare that the animals, plants and stones do in actual fact perform *Tasbeeh* in reality and for this reason the Qur'ān states explicitly:

"The seven heavens and the earth and all beings therein declare His glory. There is not a thing in but celebrates His praise. And yet you understand not. Verily He is oft for bearing, Most forgiving." (17:44)

In this respect two things become clear: firstly, Everything in the Universe perform the *Tasbeeh* of Allah and, secondly, men and *Jinn* are unable to perceive their *Tasbeeh*. This means that in actual fact these parts of the Univers is busy singing Allah praises. But this *Tasbeeh* cannot be perceived by men. But sometimes such *Tasbeeh* is made to been seen and heard by the Prophets (*Alaihis Salām*) as a sign of a miracle to them. This was one of Nabi Dawud (*Alaihis Salām*)'s specialities.

Iron Becomes Soft in His Hands

Regarding this, the Qur'ān states:

"It was we who taught him the making of coats of mail for your benefit to guard you from each others violence will you then be grateful?"

(21:80)

Hazrat Dawud عليه السلام is the first person who through being shown by Divine Revelation made armour clothing made out of iron rings, which were soft and light could be used for protection in the field of battle while still being able to move about with ease. This proved to be of great benefit to the soldiers in battle.

Speaking and Conversing to the Birds

Both Nabi Dawud عليه السلام and his son Sulaiman عليه السلام were granted from Allah's side one more special gifts in that both of them were given the knowledge of the speech of birds. A detailed discussion of this follows under the history of Nabi Sulaiman عليه السلام.

In Bukhari's *Kitabul Ambiya* there is a report that Hazrat Dawud عليه السلام used to complete a full recitation of the Zabbur in such a short time that he used to start it as he started tying the saddle to his horse and finished the reading just as he finished tying the saddle. He also had the ability to pronounce words so fast that what another person would require hours to read and pronounce, he would do so in very little time, much less that the ordinary person.

The Matter of Farm Lands

The Qur'ān states:

"And remember Dawud and Sulaiman when they gave judgment in the matter of the field into which the sheep of certain people had

strayed by night we did witness their judgment.

To Sulaiman we inspired the right understanding of the matter to each of them judgment and knowledge." (21:78)

All the *Mufasssireen* in explaining the above verse relate the story according to the reports by Abdullah bin Masud and Abdullah bin Abbaas ؓ that once two persons entered upon Hazrat Dawud ؑ with a case. The plaintiff complaint that the other person's sheep entered his cultivated field and trampled over his growing field and so destroyed everything that was growing there.

Nabi Dawud (*AlaihisSalām*)'s judgement in the case was that seeing the amount of loss suffered by the complainant but was more or less equal in value to the flock of sheep of the respondent, the flock of sheep should be granted to the complainant as compensation for his loss.

At that time Sulaiman ؑ was a young boy of about eleven years. Its was sitting near his father at the time. He said to his father: "Father your judgement seems to be correct. However, I feel it would be more appropriate and suitable if the whole flock of sheep should be granted to the complainant so that he can make use of its milk and wool and that the respondent be ordered to repair the losses of the cultivated land and bring it back to the state in which it was prior to the damage. Then when he has restored the cultivated crops to that level he may take back his flock."

Nabi Dawud ؑ approved of this judgement wholeheartedly. The Qur'ān also mentions that this Judgement was move fitting and praises the understanding of Hazrat Sulayman ؑ; as if Sulayman (*AlaihisSalām*)'s judgement seemed better. It does not however mean that because of

superiority in this one matter that Sulaiman عليه السلام was higher in rank or more superior to his father; because the Qur'ān gives over all more superiority to Nabi Dawud عليه السلام.

The Story of the Fat Tailed Sheep

In *Surah Saud* the story is told in this manner:

"Has the story of the disputants reached you. Behold they climbed over the wall of the private chamber.

When they entered the presence of Dawud, And he was terrified of them they said: "Fear not, we are two disputants, one of whom has wronged the other, decide now between us with truth and treat us not with injustice but guide as to the even path.

"This man is my brother. He has ninety-nine ewes and I have but one.

Yet he says: "Commit her to my care and he is (moreover) harsh tone in speech.

Dawud said: He has undoubtedly wronged you in demanding your single ewe to be added to his flock of ewes. Truly many are the partners (in business) who wrong each other.

"Not so do those who believe and work deeds of righteousness;

And how few they are?

And Dawud realised that we had tested him.

He asked forgiveness of his Lord, fell down bowing in prostration and turned (to Allah in repentance).

So we forgave him this (lapse), he enjoyed indeed, a near approach to us, and a beautiful place of (final) return." (37:21—25)

"O Dawud we did indeed make you a vicegerent on earth.

So judge you between men in truth (and justice).

Not follow you the lusts of your heart, for they will mislead you from the path of Allah. For those who wander astray from the path of Allah is a penalty grievous, for that they cannot forget the day of Account. (37:21—26)

In these verses there is mention of a test of Nabi Dawud ﷺ from Allah. Initially he did not understand it was a test but suddenly the realisation came to him that this is a test from Allah and immediately as is the case with Allah's chosen Messengers, he turned to Allah in repentance, seeking forgiveness, which was granted by Allah, and led further to his acquiring a place of high rank with Allah.

The Tafseer of the Verses

The Qur'ān only mentions as much as in quoted above. There is no detailed description of the test. In this respect some *Mufasssirs* went depended on various Israeli stories and fabrication to explain the matter, but these are not acceptable at all.

Maulana Hifzur Rahmaan Seoharwy discusses all those stories in detail and finally came to the following conclusion: "In our opinion the best interpretation for those verses is that which best fits in with the wording and connection with the preceding verses and is in accordance with the following verses and is best in understanding the

sequence of wordings, and that which is based on a report of Abdullah bin Abbaas ؓ. That '*Athar*' of Abudullah bin Abbas is as follows: Abdullah bin Abbaas ؓ says that Nabi Dawud ؑ has for the sake of division of work divided them into four days: one solely for *Ibaadah*, one day for judging cases in disputes, one day for himself and one day for preaching and guidance of Bani Israel."

But among those days most importance was granted to the day set aside solely for worship of Allah. In actual fact no other day of his was ever completely devoid of *Ibaadat*, but one day was specially set out for it. During that day no other work was touched. The Qur'ān refers to him being *Innahu Owwabun*, a reference to this special quality.

Further the Qur'ān and the history of Bani Israel tells us that Hazrat Dawud ؑ used to close the doors around him as he proceeded with glorifying Allah and praising His name, so that there can be no disturbance. In other words there was only one day when it was extremely difficult to reach him as he was completely cut off from Bani Israel, when as on the other days there was always a chance to meet him in cases of unforeseen circumstances.

Even though the setting aside of a special day for *Ibaadat* is in itself a praiseworthy deed, in such a manner that a person has no contact at all with other human beings, yet is it something which would be against the aims and objects of being "a Prophet" or of being "a *Khalifa* on earth." Moreover Allah did not create Nabi Dawud ؑ to be secluded ascetic, but instead made him a *Nabi* and granted him vicegerency and sent him for the leadership and guidance of his people. Similarly his life's main aim was "guidance of mankind" and "service to mankind" and was not based on "abundance of worship."

Hence Allah wanted to test Nabi Dawud ﷺ by sending two men to him with a dispute on the special day set aside for *Ibaadat*, jumping over the wall of his special privately secluded place and entering unto him. When Hazrat Dawud ﷺ saw the two men in front of him he naturally experienced fear. They quickly realized it and put him at ease and told him the reason for their coming was for him to give judgement in a dispute between them. He listened to them and gave judgement.

At this stage the Qur'ān turns away from the judgement as it seems logical to anyone with thinking faculties, that Hazrat Dawud (*Alaihis Salām*)'s judgement was correct, and only emphasized and highlighted that part of the story which dealt with guidance viz performing an injustice on others by force of your might.

Anyway after giving judgement Nabi Dawud ﷺ immediately became aware of the fact that Allah had tested him. He immediately understood and repented with sincerity, prostrating to Allah and begging for forgiveness. Allah accepted his plea for forgiveness and gave him this advice. O Dawud, We have made you our *Khalifa* on earth and your duty is to perform this duty with diligence and to remember at all times that on this path it is of the utmost importance to act with justice and not to stray from the straight path.

Nabi Dawud (Alaihis Salām)'s Life Span

Hazrat Dawud ﷺ had a very long life span and ruled over Israel for a period of seventy years. According to the Torah he was buried at a place called Sidon.

Lessons

1. When Allah decides to appoint someone as an eminent messenger of his and to endow him with special beautiful

qualities, He causes his natural ability to shine from the initial stages.

2. Some times it happens that we consider something to be insignificant or unimportant but later the unfolding events prove that thing to be of utmost importance.
3. There has always been a major difference between the 'Khalifa of Allah' on the one side and a "Shaitanic king" on the other side. The former in spite of being in possession of pomp and splendour is always inclined towards humility and towards service towards fellow-men, whereas the latter is always found to be arrogant, egotism, oppression and injustice, looking upon his fellow-men as a means towards earning his own comforts and desires.
4. It is Divine Law that the person who has reached a stage of the height of his honour, if he then admits Allah's gifts to him and expressed thanks and gratitude, to Him, Allah will increase His bounties towards him. The whole life of Nabi Dawud عليه السلام is living proof and evidence of this.
5. Even though *Deen* has a great connection with spiritualism, still we find that worldly power (*Khilaafat*) is a great support and ally for it. *Deen* is the guarantee for *Deen* as well as worldly reparations whereas *Khilaafat* and power is the means towards acquiring a just system of organisation. We have the well-known quotation from Hazrat Usman رضي الله عنه:
 "Undoubtedly Allah accomplished through the man of power (*Khalifa*) that which He does not always acquire through the Qur'ān."

6. Allah has mentioned in the various verses of the Qur'ān on the subject of granting kingdom and sovereignty indicated that a man should remember thoroughly that kingdom and sovereignty over land, the giving and the taking thereof is solely in Allah's Hands. For this the history of the world's greatest emperors and despotic values are adequate evidence.

The Qur'ān states:

"Say: O Allah, Lord of Power (and Rule).

You give power to whom you please and You strip of power from whom you please.

You endue with honour whom You please, and You bring low whom you please. In your Hand is all good and you have power over all things."

(3:26)

However He has made a fixed law for the granting and taking away of Power, which may be called the '*Sunnat* of Allah': That law is this that nations are granted power and government in two ways viz., firstly as Divine inheritance and secondly through 'worldly means'. According to the first way, when power is granted when the beliefs and deeds of the people are in accordance with Allah's will. In other words the beliefs in Allah is correct and firm and in their deeds the individual as well as the whole society are righteous as would be described as '*Saaliheen*' in the Qur'ān.

If the nation is such, the nation is worthy of being granted Allah's title of being "*Khilafat Ilahiyya*" i.e., in this world they are vicegerents of Allah and the true successors of the Prophets (*Alaihis Salām*). And Allah's promise is that the people who in beliefs and deeds are the heirs of the Prophets (*Alaihis Salām*) they will be the heirs of this earth

as well as hereafter—and even if there should stand a vast mountain between themselves the inheritance of the hereafter, they will overcome that obstacle and Allah will fulfill his promise to them. Says Allah:

"Before this we wrote in the Zabbur after the message (given to Musa عليه السلام): My Servant, the righteous shall inherit the earth." (21:105)

"For the earth is Allah's to give as a heritage to such of His servants as He pleases." (7:128)

In these verses Allah's pleasure lies with those who are His righteous servants and if this righteousness is not found in any nation, then in spite of them being claimants to being attached to Islām, they cannot become the recipients of the heritage, and they will not be able to lay claim to 'Divine *Khilaafat*'. And for such a people the promise of Allah does not fit.

A warning lesson (*Ibrat*) is provided by the fact that the king sitting on a throne is not being given power to rule over others just because Allah is pleased with him, but because the true heirs of rule and power here as a result of their bad deeds lost the right to take up the power. And now for the sake of the benefit of this world it is not a condition for power and rule that the ruler should be a Muslim or a *Kaafir* or a *Mushrik*.

Allah says: "And Allah granteth His authority to whom He pleases." (2:247)

If a Muslim should try to bring about a change for the better in his corrupt life and adopt the ways of the pious and righteous ones, then Allah gives them the same good news which He promises.

"Allah has promised to those among you who believe and work righteous deeds, that He will of a surely grant them in the land Inheritance (of power) as He granted it to those before them; that He will established their religion—the one which he chose for them and that he will charge (their state) after the fear, in which they lived to one of security and peace."

(24:55-56)

One Very Important Point

There is absolutely no doubt therein that the worship Allah and to glorify Him and praise Him is the main objective in the life of any Muslim. However for those persons whom He had chosen for the guidance of mankind or for the service of mankind it is better to remain busy with delivering the duty for which they had been chosen than to be busy with abundant *Ibaadat*.

No doubt for a sufi or an ascetic, the more he secludes himself from the rest of mankind, spending his time in worship, the more he rises in the ranks of sainthood. This is the opposite as in the case of the position of prophethood and the position of *Khilaafat*, there the main aim of granting these positions of anyone is to serve mankind and to guide them aright, and not to become more pious.

An Importnat Clarification

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy has, after explaining Nabi Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s story in detail, made an important point. That point is as follows: Our Nabi  has said on one occasion that those reports of the *Ahlul Kitaab* which are not against the Qur'ān and Islamic teachings, may be quoted. But we people have disregarded the chief condition in this statement viz., that those reports should

not be against the Qur'ān and Islamic teachings, and have not only begun to quote all manner of Israeli *Riwaayaat*, but have also quoted those reports in our *Tafseer* of the Qur'ān. This is wrong and to give these Israeli *Rewaayaats* a place in our interpretation of Qur'ānic verses can be very destructive. The correct line of action is that which the research scholars of Islam have adopted that there should be complete faith in the verses of the Qur'ān and to avoid all heretical interpretation and to consider such interpretations as distortion of the Qur'ān. Their aim is to keep the Qur'ān pure of all Israeli *Riwayaat*.¹

For detail see *Qasasul Qur'ān*, Vol. 2, p. 171-172

Hazrat Shamweel عليه السلام

In the story of Hazrat Shamweel عليه السلام, Tauloot, Nabi Dawud and Jaaloot are also mentioned. For this reason a concise description of them follows:

Hazrat Shamweel عليه السلام in the Qur'ān

The name of Hazrat Shamweel عليه السلام is not mentioned in the Qur'ān. However in the following verse the reference is to him.

"Have you not turned your vision to the chiefs of the Children of Israel after (the time of) Musa عليه السلام.

They said to a Prophet among them: Appoint for us a king that we may fight in the cause of Allah."
(2:246)

Taaloot

In accordance with this prayer and request by Bani Israel to Hazrat Shamweel عليه السلام, Allah sent Tauloot to be that king.

"The Prophet said to them: Allah has appointed Tauloot as king over you."
(2:247)

Jaaloot

The leader of the enemy force was Jaaloot, a very big giant of a man who is mentioned in *Surah Baqarah*.

(249—251)

***Hazrat Daawood* ﷺ**

In the battle against Jaaloot the one from Bani Israel who showed bravery in fighting Jaaloot and killed him was Hazrat Dawud ﷺ.

***The Mission of Hazrat Shamweel* ﷺ**

During the time of the Hazrat Yushaa ﷺ Bani Israel entered the Holy Land and Yushaa ﷺ remained with them looking after their spiritual welfare and guidance. For the purpose of setting disputes, he appointed Qadis. This system continued among them.

The historians say that the Israelite dislike of Tauloot as a king was based upon the fact that Prophet hood among them was always continued through the lineage of Nabi Yaqoob (*Alaihis Salām*)'s son Laadi while rule over them and chieftainship was always through the lineage of the second son, Yahuda. Now it meant that the leadership would shift to the offspring of Binyameen. This caused jealousy to result among them which they could not tolerate.

The Qur'ān States: "Their Prophet ﷺ said to them: Allah has appointed Tauloot over you they said: "How can he exercise authority over us and he is not even with wealth in abundance.

The Prophet ﷺ said: .

"Allah has chosen him above you and has gifted him abundantly with knowledge and bodily

proves: Allah grants His authority to whosoever He pleases. Allah cares for all and He knows all things." (2:247)

Taaboot of Sakeena

The dispute over Taaloot's appointment continued until they demanded from Nabi Shamweel ﷺ that if his appointment was from Allah's side then he should show some sign. In asking to that Nabi Shamweel ﷺ replied:

"A Sign of his authority is that there shall come to you the Ark of the covenants with assurance therein of security from your Lord and the relics left by the family of Musa ﷺ and the family of Haroon ﷺ. Carried by the Angels." (2:248)

Soon after this prophecy the Angels brought the Taaboot which had been lost to certain enemies. This box was brought to Bani Israel. This meant that now Bani Israel had no more grounds for objection or excuse. They were forced to accept Taaloot as King over them.

The Battle between Taaloot and Jaaloot

Hazrat Taaloot made a public announcement to the Israelites that they should move into battle against their enemies, the Palestinians and they moved off. When they came to a river where an incident happened. The Qur'ān tells the story:

"When Taaloot set forth with the armies, he said: Allah will test you at the stream: If any drink of its water He goes not with my army. Only those who taste not of it goes on with me:

A mere sip out of the hand is excused."

But they all dunk of it except a few.

When they crossed the river, He and the faithful ones with him they said: "This day we cannot cope with Jaaloot and his forces."

But those who were convinced that they must meet Allah, said:

"How often by Allah's will had a small force vanquished a big one?"

Allah is with those who patiently persevere."

(2:249)

In short the result was that those who at the river drank of the water and so disobeyed an order said that they would be unable to cope in battle with the might of Jaaloot, having no strength to match him, but on the other hand those who with held themselves and obeyed their *Ameer*, said without any fear: "We will definitely meet the enemy in battle because Allah has always shown that small forces defeat larger and stronger forces on condition that there be faith in Allah, sincerity and stead fastness. These *Mujahideen* then made sincere supplications to Allah for help and success.

The Qur'ān further relates:

"When they advanced further to meet Jaaloot and his forces, they prayed: "Our Lord pour out constancy on us and make our steps firm. Help us against those who reject faith."

The Bravery of Hazrat Dawud ﷺ

The army of Bani Israel under the general ship of Hazrat Taaloot stood ready in battle lines against Jaaloot. Among

them was a young man named Daawood ﷺ. He entangled Jaaloot in combat and showed great courage as he managed to kill the giant Jaaloot. The Qur'ān states:

"By Allah's will they, (the Israelites) routed them (the philistines) and his forces and Dawud killed Jaaloot."
(2:251)

In this battle Banu Israel was successful and during this time Nabi Shamweel ﷺ passed away.

Lessons and Warnings

1. The passion for freedom and for the protection of one's rights are feelings that first are awakened in the prominent ones among nations and from there it spreads gradually to the ordinary members. The nation among whom those prominent ones are most in number these passions tend to be strongest and most widespread.
2. Islam clarifies this point that sovereignty and leadership is not dependant upon wealth and riches, nor on offspring or lineage, but knowledge and strength are such qualities which could be made criteria, because truth and justice, proper planning and correct opinion which are prominent conditions for government and rule are created by wealth, lineage and offspring. For a proper ruler it is required that he should be "abundantly endowed with knowledge and with bodily prowess."
3. When truth and false hood meet in battlê and on the side of truth we find sincere ones with passions of sacrifice in them standing up to defend the side of truth and inside them there is self-reliance and

dependence on Allah, then the criterion for success does not lie in the numbers of fighters on both sides. The majority becomes overwhelmed by the minority and the minority will end the battle as victorious.

Then came a time when among Bani Israel there was no *Nabi* and no *Rasul*. Neither did they have a single King. Because of this various of the neighbouring nations took the chance to attack them. In this manner a Palestinian nation from the area of Ghazza attacked them and Bani Israel were defeated to such an extent that they were force to give up the Taaboot' a box in which there were the original copy of the Torah and certain relies which originally belonged to Nabi Musa ﷺ and Nabi Haroon ﷺ.

At such a time Allah appointed one of the Qadis as a *Nabi* for the guidance of Bani Israel. Historians say Shamweel was a member of the offspring of Nabi Haroon. The *Nabi* to Whom reference is made in *Surah Baqarah* in the 32nd *Ruku* is this Nabi Shamweel ﷺ.

The Appointment of Hazrat Taaloot

During the time of Nabi Shamweel Bani Israel continued with their opposition to truth. Then they asked Nabi Shamweel to pray to Allah to appoint for them a king under whose leadership they would go into combat against tyrannical rulers and proceed into *Jihad* to bring an end to calamities brought down upon them.

In answer to the *Du'a* by Nabi Shamweel, Allah said to him:

"Is it not possible that if you were commanded to fight that you will not fight.

Upon this the chiefs of the tribes said:

"How could we refuse to fight in the cause of Allah Seeing that we were turned out of our homes and our families."
(2:246)

Thereupon Nabi Shamweel again turned to Allah and Allah appointed Taaloot as king over them. Taaloot was a man superior in body and knowledge among Bani Israel. But again were they not satisfied with his appointment, raising all sorts of objections.

Hazrat Sulaiman عليه السلام

Lineage and Childhood

Hazrat Sulaiman عليه السلام is the son of Nabi Dawud عليه السلام and Allah has blessed him with intelligence and a special ability to settle disputes. In the respect we have already seen how he passed judgement between two disputants who brought their case to the court of his father.

Special Status of Sulaiman عليه السلام

The Historians state that Sulaiman عليه السلام had reached the age of manhood when Nabi Dawud عليه السلام passed away and Allah made him the successor of his father as king and prophet.

The Qur'ān states:

"And Sulaiman was Dawud (*Alaihis Salām*)'s heir." (26:16)

"To each of them [Dawud عليه السلام and Sulaiman عليه السلام] we gave judgement and knowledge." (21:79)

Special Bounties on Sulaiman عليه السلام

As in the case of Hazrat Dawud عليه السلام, Allah bestowed on Sulaiman عليه السلام some specialities and points of superiority

and granted unto him some such bounties which became a special sign of his high rank.

Understanding the Speech of Birds

The Qur'ān states:

"And Sulaiman was Dawud's heir. He said: "O People, we have been taught the speech of birds and on us has been bestowed (a little) of all things. This is indeed Grace manifest (from Allah.)
(26:16)

From the manner in which the Qur'ān mentions the gift it appears Namī that this was no ordinary gift. It was something that too could be called a *Mou'jizah* a miracle as it something above and beyond normal natural abilities and is solely a gift from Allah which may be mentioned as one of Allah's special signs which is granted to His special chosen ones.

Sulaiman (Alaihis Salām)'s Control over the Wind

Regarding this the Qur'ān states:

"And to Sulaiman We made the wind obedient.
Its early morning stride was a months journey
And its evening stride was a months journey."
(34:12)

And further:

"Then we subjected the wind to his power to flow gently to his order whosoever he willed."
(38:36)

In these verses three things are being mentioned. Firstly it says the wind was made obedient to him. Secondly it states

that the wind were so under his control that in spite of being strong, or fast and cold, at his command it became gentle and slow bringing comfort with it. Thirdly in spite of being gentle and comfortable its speed was such it used to travel in one morning the distance normally covered in a month. In other words it travelled almost faster than over presents aeroplanes. This was also one of the specialities of Hazrat Sulaiman عليه السلام which should be accepted without any other interpretations.

Control over the Jinn and Animals

It is said that Hazrat Sulaiman once made the following *Duah*:

"O My Lord forgive me and grant me a kingdom which suits not another after me.

For you are the Granter, of bounties (without measure). (38:35)

Allah accepted this *Du'a* and granted him such a wonderful government which was not granted to anyone before him and was not granted to another after him. This power of his extended not only over human beings, but also over *Jinn* and the animals and the air and all of these used to be obedient to him. [Note the *Jinn* were also a creation of Allah as was already discussed under the story of Hazrat Adam عليه السلام].

The Building of Baitul Muqaddas

According to Bukhari and Muslim there is a authentic *Hadith* reported by Hazrat Abu Zarr Ghaffari رضي الله عنه, which says that just as Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام was the builder of the *Masjid-ul-Haraam* and became the cause for the settlement at Makkah, so also Nabi Yaqoob عليه السلام laid the foundation for baitul

Muqaddas and so *Bait-ul-Muqaddas* became a place of settlement. Thereafter after a long time the *Masjid* and the town's settlement was renewed by Hazrat Sulaiman عليه السلام and due to his control over the *Jinns* a splendours building came into being. Apart from this building the *Jinns* also erected various other buildings for him as the Qur'ān mentions:

"And of the evil ones were some who dived for him and did other work besides. And it was we who guarded them."
(21:82)

And further:

"And there were jinns that worked in front of him, by the leave of his Lord, and if any of them turned aside from Our Command, We made him taste of the penalty of the blazing fire.

They worked for him as he desires, making arches, Images, Basins as large as reservoirs, And cooking cauldrons fixed (in their places).

"Work you, sons of Dawud عليه السلام with thanks! But few of My Servants are grateful."

(34:12—13)

And further:

"And before Sulaiman were marshalled His hosts—of *Jinns* and men and birds and they were all kept in order in ranks."
(27:17)

And further:

"And subjected to Sulaiman عليه السلام were made the evil ones, (including) every kind of builder and diver.

As also others bound together in fetters

Such are Our bounties, whether you bestow them (on others) or with hold them, No, account will be asked.

And he enjoyed indeed a near approach to us and a beautiful place of (final) return."

(37:36—40)

The buildings of the Era of Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ which came into existence as a result of his control over the *Jinns* cause onlookers and visitors to be astonished even today. The stones were of such exquisite beauty. One wonder where it could have been brought from, and how could those stones have been laid in their places so high up.

Treasures of Copper

With regard to those grand buildings the *Mufasssireen* mention that Allah had copper melted for Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ according to his needs. The Qur'ān however does not make mention of the copper mines.

The Queen of Sheba

The Qur'ān mentions this story in concise manner so that the main object of the story becomes known is to serve as an admonition moreover from the story the point already mentioned comes to the front viz., that Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ understand the languages of birds. The story is told in *Surah Saba* from verse 36 to verse 44, and is told by Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy in this manner"

"Once in the court of Nabi Sulaimān ﷺ with all its pomp and splendour, Hudhud was found to absent from his place. He said: "I find Hudhud absent from his place. This absence of his is bound to be severely punished. I shall either

punish him heavily or will slaughter him unless he can explain it with a good reason for his absence.

Soon thereafter Hudhud appeared and in reply to Nabi Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s question replied that he has come with such news that has not reached Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ up to then. He explained that in the region of Yemen there lived a queen whom Allah has granted everything. The throne on which she sits is a very grand one filled with beautiful things.

This queen and her people were sun-worshippers and *Shaitan* has misled them and they do not worship Allah, the One Creator of the Universe.

Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ said:

"The test of whether you speak the truth or falsehood will soon be known. If what you say is true, take the letter of mine and hand it to her and wait for a reply to see what she says about it."

When the Queen received the letter she said to her courtiers and advisors: "I have received this letter in which is written":

"This letter is from Sulaiman and is in the name of Allah who is Most Beneficent, Most Merciful. You should not rebel against us or disobey. Come to me as a obedient servant of Allah."

The queen read the letter and said: O Members of My Kingdom You know that I never take any step without consulting with you. Advise me as to what to do.

They replied: "There is no need to be over-awed by it. We are strong and possess the means to go into battle. As for

advice, the matter lies in your hands. Whatever you consider suitable, you may order and command."

She replied:

"Undoubtedly we are strong and have power but in this matter with Sulaiman we should not be hasty. First of all we have to ascertain the extent of his strength, because the manner in which his message reached us, shows us that we should carefully consider what steps to take. My intention is that a few messengers be sent to him with some valuable gifts from which he will be able to gauge our pomp and splendour. And so that we may also ascertain what he wants from us. If indeed he is a very strong power, then our fighting him will be useless, because it is the habit of strong Kings that when they enter any city after conquest, they destroy them and humiliate the highly ranked ones. Why should we invite such ruin upon ourselves?"

The presents were sent and when the messengers with the presents entered into the presence of Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ, he said: "You and your queen has misunderstood my message. Do you think that with these gifts, with which you seem to be very pleased, you can flatter and seduce me. Yet you can see that what Allah has granted me, your presents are nothing in comparison therewith. Take your gifts back. Tell your queen that if she does not obey my call, I will attack Saba with such a large force against which you will be incapable of putting up a defence. Then I will humiliate you and expel you from your country."

The Messenger returned to Saba and told the whole story to their Queen. They also related to her the great splendour which they had witnessed around armed Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ and related how he ruled not only over men, but also *Jinn* and animals. She immediately realised that to fight him would be an invitation to complete destruction and also decided to heed to his call.

In the letter of Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ was one sentence: "Wa'tounee *Muslimeen*" "And come to me as submitters to Allah." Because the Queen of Saba was not on the deed of Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ, she understood it to be on the literal meaning, which meant she had to come to him, while submitting and surrendering to him. She decided to do that and started the travel in his direction through revelation Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ came to know she was coming. He told his courtiers that he wanted her throne to be brought there before she arrives. One *Jinn* offered to bring it. Then Nabi Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s *wazir* offered to bring her royal throne within the wink of an eye and immediately the throne was present. Upon this Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ said: "This is the favour of my Lord. He tests me to find whether I am grateful or ungrateful. And whosoever shows gratitude, actually does benefit to his own self. And whosoever is disobedient, then Allah is unconcerned of his disobedience and the burden thereof falls upon the disobedient one."

The Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ ordered that some changes be made to the throne. He wanted to see on seeing it, whether she will come to realize reality or not.

A short while later the Queen of Saba arrived and she was asked: "Is your throne like this? The intelligent queen replied: "It looks like it, as if it is it." She further replied: "I have been informed of your unequalled and unrivalled

strength. For this reason I come to you as a submitting and obedient subject and having seen the matter of the throne, it gives me more indication of your strength. Hence I declare my submission and obedience to you."

The queen understood that by declared her submission to him, she has obeyed his call to her, but her sun-worshipping belief prevented her from properly understanding his aim. Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ realised she did not understand properly and devised another plan to bring her to realisation. Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ ordered the *Jinns* to prepare a magnificent glass mansion palace, shining like water, that was unique in its splendour and appearance. In the fore-court leading to its entrance he had a big pool dug out and this was filled with water. The rest of the fore-court had a floor that was beautifully laid in with pieces of crystal so that any spectator would believe that this court was flowing with water.

The Queen of Saba was told to reside in this beautiful palace, and as she came to the fore-court she found "the flowing water." As she saw this she prepared to enter the water by lifting her clothes upto above the knees. Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ saw this and said: "There is no need for that. This is not water.

The whole palace and its fore-court is from shining cyrstial."

She then understood Hazrat Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s aim and like a sorrowful person exclaimed: "O Lord, by my worshipping brings other than you, I have done myself a great wrong. I now together with Sulaiman ﷺ, have faith in you alone."

In this matter she was brought to the realization of the meaning of "Come to me as one submitting to Allah."

Where is Saba

One of the well-known tribes of Qahtani is the Saba tribe. Saba was the great grand father of the tribe of Saba. This is according to Arab historians and some modern researches. Saba was the nickname. His actual name was Umar or Abdu Shams. He was noted to be a man of great bravery and courage and he was the founder of the rule over the tribe.

Their time according to historians was 1100 years before Christ. Their centre of government was in the Southern portion of Arabia in eastern region of Yemen; and the capital was a place called Ma'aarib. It was also known as the town of Saba. The area stretched up to Hadramant and on the other side the sphere of their influence went so far as the continent of Africa. In English the land was known as Sheba.

In this story the Qur'ān did not mention the name of the Queen, but according to Arab and Jewish sources her name was Bilqees.

Hudhud

The Qur'ān has mentioned in very clear terms that the messenger between Hazrat Sulaiman عليه السلام and Saba was a bird called Hud-hud. In view of the already explained fact that Nabi Sulaiman عليه السلام knew how to converse with the birds it seems there is no scope for any other interpretation here.

The Throne of the Queen

The description of the throne of the Queen of Saba was given by Hud-Hud, and in this regard the miraculous way in which Hazrat Sulaiman عليه السلام had it brought to him and changed

by way of a *Mou'jizah*, it also seems that to interpret it any other way is unsound.

The Queen's Acceptance of Islām

The Queen on having seen the prophetic splendour of Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ came forward and embraced Islām. In this whole episode this was actually Nabi Sulaiman's ﷺ aim to get her to submit to and worship Allah as he indicated to her in his first letter. However at that time the Queen could not properly understand his intention.

Queen's Marriage

In the Qur'ān and the *Hadith* there is nothing to state such a marriage did in fact take place, nor is there any denial thereof.

The Death of Sulaiman ﷺ

According to the Qur'ān with regard to the death of Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ it is said the *Jinns* were busy constructing a very big building when the news reached Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ of his coming death. However the *Jinns* had no news thereof. They remained busy with their duties and it was only after the ants had eaten the stick on which he leaned and he fell down dead, then the *Jinns* came to realise he had died a long time ago. Then they felt sorry that they did not know the unseen otherwise they would have been freed from their duties, which they continued to perform and of fear for him.

The Qur'ān states:

"Then, when we decreed, (Sulaiman's) death nothing showed them His death, except a little worm of the earth, which kept slowly growing

away at his staff, so when he fell down, the *Jinns* saw plainly, that if they had known the unseen, they would not have tarried in the humiliating penalty (of their task). (34:14)

It is said that when the *Jinns* became aware of his death, the building had been completed. That's why they were so sorry that if they had known the unseen, they would have been freed much earlier. At this stage we must point out that the Qur'ān actually here wishes to explain how Hazrat Sulaiman عليه السلام died but at the same time wishes to rebuke Bani Israel for a wrong belief they held. They believed that the *Jinns* were Knowers of the unseen. The Qur'ān wishes to indicate to them that if the jinns were knower of the unseen they would not have remained busy with the building of buildings like Baitul Muqaddas etc. Thus the Manner in which the death took place made the *Jinns* admit that their claim to being knowers of the unseen was completely wrong.

Tafseer of Some Points

In the Holy Qur'ān an incident pertaining to horses for *Jihad* is explained in his manner:

"To Dawood We gave Solomon (for a son) How excellent in our service Ever did he turn (to us).

Before they were brought before him at eventide, losers of the highest breeding and swift on foot.

And he said: "Truly do I love the love of Sood. With a view to the Glory of my Lord." Until the Sun was hidden in the veil (of the night) "Bring them back to me."

There he passed his hand over their legs and their necks." (38:30—33)

In the *Tafseer* of these verses Maulana Hifzur Rahman had a deep discussion and from the *Tafseer* of Ibn Jarer and Imam Razi he quoted a report by Hazrat Abdullah bin Abbaas  from Ali bin Abi Talhah. In this report there is no mention of Sulaiman's *Salaah* having become '*Qadau*', neither is there any mention of the sun having set, nor is there any mention of slaughtering the horses. The story being told is this at a time of an important matter of *Jihad* Hazrat Sulaiman  ordered that the *Jihad* horses be brought before him from their stables. He was a man with very good knowledge about the lineage of horses and their pedigree as well as their qualities and when he found them to be of a high quality and of good stock, and in large number he was pleased and he said:

"My love for these horses is part of such a love for things which is connected with the *Zikr* of Allah."

Just at that time the horses were sent back to the stables, so that when Hazrat Sulaiman  looked towards them again, they were removed from his eye-sight. He then ordered that they be brought back to him. When they were brought back, he touched their legs and their necks out of love for them and by virtue of the fact that they were animals used in *Jihad*.

According to this explanation *Innee Ahbabbu Hubbal Khayri'a Zikree'* means that verily my love for things and wealth, viz., the love for the houses of *Jihad*, is as a result of *Zikrullah*. And the term "*Tawaarat bil Hijaab*" the pronoun in it refers to the horses who disappeared from his sight, and there is no need to have it refer to the sun. And "*Taufikau mas-han bis sooqi wal aa'naaq*" is on its literal meaning viz., that he touched them on their upper legs and necks.

The Testing and Trial

In a very concise manner the Qur'ān has mentioned Hazrat Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s test from Allah's side:

"And We did try Sulaiman. We placed on his throne a body without life, but he did turn (to us in true devotion).

And said: O Lord, forgive me." (38:34)

In these verses, it does not say when Sulaiman ﷺ was tested, who was he. It only says 'a body' was placed on his throne. Even in the *Hadith* too there is no detail. Hence Maulana Hifzur Rahman had discussed the story taking into account the opinions of the *Mufasssireen*. In the end he writes:

"Imam Razi says that when Allah says He put Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ to a test, the test was this that he had to suffer a very heavy sickness and body which was thrown on his throne was his very sick body which appeared almost like a body without a soul. Then "he turned to Allah" mean is that after that he was restored to full health. In other words the aim was to bring to his notice that in spite of him being the ruler, not only was his ruling power not in his power and hands, but even his life too was not under his control. This was done to bring him to bending down in front of Allah like the other eminent prophets, and messengers and to seek Allah's forgiveness.

The Valley of the Ants

The Qur'ān says:

"And before Sulaiman ﷺ were marshalled his hosts of jinn and men, and birds and they were all kept in order and ranks. At length where they came to a (lowly) valley of ants one of the ants

said: "O you ants, get into your habitations, lest Sulaiman and his hosts crush you (under foot) without knowing.

So he smiled amused at her speech and he said: "O my Lord, so order me that I may be grateful for your favours which you bestowed upon me and my parents, and that I may work the righteousness that pleases you." (27:17—19)

Regarding the Valley of the ants and the ants, many questions arise. Some people have tried to answer them with Israeli *Riwayaat* and Jewish fabrications, but all these discussions are fare-fatched and without substantiation. The Qur'ān and the *Hadith* are free of such nonsensical stories.

The aim behind this story is that Allah had granted Hazrat Dawood ﷺ and Sulaiman ﷺ the ability to understand the speech of animals, which is one of the great things granted to them. This knowledge is different from other worldly knowledge and arts, but were two miracles granted to two eminent prophets. Hence just after mentioning this special bounty of Allah, comes the story of how Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ listened to the conversation of an insignificant animal like the ant in the same way that a man listens to another man. Then also when Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ had experienced it with certainty he, as it fitting for an eminent messenger of Allah expressed thanks and gratitude for the gift. To further show the importance of this incident we may mention that this *Surah* has been called *Surah al-Naml*. (The Ant)

Most historians gave their opinion that this "Valley of Ants" lies near the town of Askelon, as Ibn Batuta has mentioned, or that it lies between Bayt Jabron and Askelon. Other *Mufasssireen* state that it is in Syria.

One brought Saba's Throne

During the story of the Queen of Saba it was mentioned that when Hazrat Sulaiman had come to know that she was enroute coming to him, he addressed his countries saying that he would like someone to bring her throne to him. Who was prepared to do that? A *Jinn* offered to bring it before the gathering finished. Then one of those in the court of Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ—one of those who had knowledge of the Book—offered to bring the throne before a winking of the eyes.

Now two questions arise: What is the name of that person who had knowledge of the book? Who was he?

His name was Asif bin Barkhya and he was a special companion of Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ. He was also a minister (*Wazeer*). Ibn Abbas says that most *Mufasssireen* have accepted this as there.

The second question is: What is meant by knowledge of the Book. In this regard Maulana Hifzur Rahman Scharwy says the preferred verdict is that this person (Asif) was a Companion of Hazrat Sulaiman ﷺ and was someone very near to him; like Abu Bakr ؓ was to Rasulullah ﷺ. Being a closed companion he knew secrets of the Torah, the Zabbur and the Divine Names of Allah. Hence when a *Jinn* offered to bring the throne before the end of the gathering, although that time limit was short enough, but Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ actually felt that service should not be delivered by a *Jinn* but by some such servant of Allah who was very near and so that though the spiritual attention of the Messenger of Allah the act be performed as a miracle before the Queen of Sheba. For this reason Asif immediately understood Hazrat Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s reason for asking the question and offered himself to do

the work in even shorter time. He knew that with Hazrat Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s attention it will be done.

Bani Israel's Accusation

Apart from other accusations laid against Nabi Sulaiman by Bani Israel, was also this that he was a sorcerer, a worker of magic by the strength of which he had become King Sulaiman ﷺ, and that through the magic he was able to subjugate men, *Jinn*, animals and birds to his will. In this regard the Qur'ān clearly states:

"And where there came to them (Bani Israel) an apostle from Allah, confirming what was with them, A party of the people of the Book threw away the Book of Allah behind their backs. As if (it had been something) they did not know.

They followed what the evil ones gave out (falsely) against the power of Sulaiman ﷺ: the blasphemers were—not Sulaiman ﷺ, but the evil ones, teaching men magic and such thing as came down at Babylon to the angels, Harut and Marut, but none of these taught anyone such things without saying: "We are only for trial, so do not blaspheme."

They learned from them the means to sow discord between man and wife. But they could not thus harm anyone except by Allah's permission and they learned what harmed them.

Not what perfected them. And they knew that the buyers of magic would have no share in the happiness of the Hereafter. And vite was the price for which they did sell their souls, If but they knew."

(2:101—103)

With regard to the story told above the *Mufasssireen* have different viewpoints. In this we have chose a neutral view which is taken from the researches of Allama Anwar Shah Kashmiry. The summary of his view is this:

"When the *Shaitan* had taught Bani Israel magic and thereby led them astray, and they began to believe that the *Shaitans* were knowers of the unseen,—that was after the time of Nabi Sulaiman (*Alaihis Salām*)'s death—while there was no Prophet of Allah among them, at such a time, as was Allah's way with Bani Israel for many centuries, Allah sent two angels from on high to show them the path of guidance. These two angels were Harut and Marut who taught Bani Israel certain secrets taken from the Divine Names and qualities in the Torah. These secrets were and the effects thereof were quite different from the unholy effects of magic and the ignorant Israel would confuse these teachings with magic, whereas in actual fact they were higher knowledge of the secrets and when these angels taught Bani Israel these arts, they advised them that now that the reality had become known to them, and they had seen the difference between truth and falsehood, if you are now going to discard the knowledge from the book of Allah and return to magic, they would surely become *Kāafir*. This is because Allah's argument and proof has been completed against them, and they will have no excuse. The Angels actually told them that their presence was a test for Bani Israel. Are they now going to follow the teachings of the Book of Allah or are they going to discard it and follow the footsteps of Shaitan.'

However the crooked ways of Bani Israel did not leave them. They used this clean higher knowledge also for their prohibited and unclean desires as for example to bring about discord and separation between husband and wife or to mix up truth with falsehood or in using the effects of some holy

phrase or sentence to acquire prohibited acts and performance. Now to do these kinds of things, the ulama state is also to be guilty of working magic or sorcery and is also prohibited acts of *Kufr*.

In other words in the above verses the Qur'ān states that it was a false occasion of Bani Israel when they ascribed magic unto him.

Conclusion

They works of magic and teaching people magic was the work of the *Shaitans*. Nabi Sulaiman عليه السلام was innocent of it. Bani Israel actually followed the *Shaitans* and thereby threw the teachings of the Book of Allah behind their backs. And even though Harut and Marut were two angels sent down to lead Bani Israel on the right path and to teach them the secrets taken from the Divine Names and attributes of Allah in the Torah, Bani Israel by following the guidance of *Shaitans*, went towards magic practices. The Qur'ān did not mention other details and for this reason it is only compulsory upon us to believe in the description given.

Warnings and Lessons

1. The previous nations due to their own passions made various false accusations against Allah's true and chosen messengers and also laid some very bad charges against these prophets.

In these respects Bani Israel was foremost in this. On the one hand they accepted them as prophets and at the same time they accepted them to have been guilty of various shameful and immoral acts as for example the accusation of Nabi Loot and his daughters, where Nabi Loot was accused of having been involved with an

immoral act. Similarly they even went so far as to deny the prophethood of some *Nabees* and accused them of evil-deeds as for example the matter between Nabi Dawood عليه السلام and Sulaiman عليه السلام.

The Holy Qur'ān took up the task of clearing the prophets from those unfounded accusations and to paint *Deen* in its true colours and in this respect rejected the fabrications and false accusations in clear terms.

2. A major lesson for us is the fact that wrong path which Bani Israel chose to walk with regard to the character of the prophets and which the Qur'ān had rejected in clear terms, we people too have not been able to keep ourselves safe and clean that and we too had begun to use those fabricated stories in our explanations. Rasulullah ﷺ said on one occasion that those stories of the *Ahlul-Kitaab* which are not in against Qur'ān and Islāmic teachings will be in order to be quoted but we have disregarded the most important condition that these stories should "not be against Qur'ān and Islāmic teachings We have started not only to quote all manner of Israeli *Riwaayaats* but have also made them a basis for interpretation of the *Tafseer* of certain verses. The result has been that non-Muslims have even gone so far as to mention these stories as Islāmic *Riwaayaat*. Having done that they have even started to attack Islām and used these reports as a basis for these bad intentions of theirs. On the other hand these are those torch-bearers of hoeresy and atheism have used those *Riwaayaat* as a means towards declaring their unbelief, and to deny the person truths of Islām like the revival of man after death, their gathering after resurrection, paradise and hell saying unequivocally that the details which the

Mufasssireen have quoted have been taken from such Israeli *Riwaayaat*. This is what they say even though we know that for those details there are clear texts.

Anyway both these ways are wrong. To give those Israeli *Riwaayaat* a place among us especially in *Tafseer* is wrong when they are against Islāmic teachings. It can be a very destructive step, no matter how good the intention behind it. Similarly it is also wrong to use these *Riwaayaat* as a means towards rejecting clear Qur'ānic texts as that is also tantamount to misinterpretation.

The correct procedure is that opted for by the research scholars in that they have firm faith and belief in the words of the Qur'ān and consider any heretical interpretation to be misinterpretations. Their aim is to clause the Qur'ān from all Israeli *Riwaayaat* which are against Islāmic teachings.

3. There has always been a major difference between reports who were also kings and rulers on the one side and kings and rulers on the other side. The lives of the former were always filled with the fear of Allah, justice, invitation to truth and service to mankind . Whenever they have to show their ruling powers in cases where it needs to be shown it is done without pride and arrogance and if they have to show anger it will not be anger for their own sake but for Allah's sake. They do nothing for their own benefit—only for lifting up; the word of Allah. The whole lives of Nabi Yusuf ﷺ, Nabi Dawood ﷺ and Nabi Sulaiman ﷺ is an open exhibition of this. On the other hand the latter of the two's lives portray personal dignity, their own superiority and rank, injustice towards mankind etc.

By way of example, think of the uttering of Fir-own: "*Ana Rabbukumul A'laa*." "I am your Lord, Most High." And then ponder over the order of Nabi Sulaiman عليه السلام. *Allah ta'loo 'alayya wa'-toone Muslimeen*." Do not present yourself in high rank before me and come to me, submitting to Allah.

In both these sentences there is the authority of a ruler but in the case of Fir-own there is rebellion against Allah, over wholming force against human beings and together with his claim to Divinity there is also much egotism. In the statement by Nabi Sulaiman there is no elevation of the self or personal aggrandisement, but there is an invitation to glorify Allah, conveying the message and a discarding of '*Shirk*'. The same difference between 'these two statements is the difference that should always be there between those who are the inheritors of the prophets and worldly rulers.

4. The person whose whole life is solely for Allah, for him Allah makes the whole world subservient to him and he becomes such that not a step is taken except in Allah's pleasure. Hence if this person performs and exhibits some such actions which are in contrast to the general laws of cause and effect of the world, then it should be known that those acts are emanating from some one who has annihilated his self in Allah's pleasure, and therefore Allah's Hands are above his head, guiding him. Some will notice these miraculous acts and still be inclined to deny and reject them. This is the path of these who are astray. The slight path is the one which the scholars of Islām have explained in the light of the Qur'ān and *Hadith*.

5. Of the worst effects of *Shaitani* effects is that effect and whisperings of *Shaitan* which cause discord between husband and wife leading to seperation, enmity and finally to a break-up in their relationship. This is considered to be of the worst results because it is based upon lies, false accusations, abusive language and immorality. For the reason it is something very much liked by *Shaitan*.

QASASUL AMBIYAA

STORIES OF THE PROPHETS

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Rah.)



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Qasasul Ambiyaa

The Holy Qur'ān does not relate historical facts merely for the sake of telling a story which is of historical value. Its main aim in relating happenings is to draw attention to the results, conclusions and deductions from these incidents so that they become a source of guidance for men and prove to be lessons for them that appeal to their minds and emotions that from these historical events, lessons should be derived. These lessons should convince them that the existence of Allah is an undeniable fact and that His Mighty Hand is playing a major role in the affairs of men. It should also bring to their notice that to follow the stipulations of His deen brings success and leads to salvation and is the way towards all progress. That is what Islām—the natural religion—is about.

From: Qasasul Qur'ān

Preface

The most authentic and comprehensive work of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy, *Qasasul Qur'ān* needs no introduction. However, the Manner in which our friend Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version of a voluminous and bulky work he has undoubtedly, fulfilled one of the needs of this time. He has adopted such a method of abridgement whereby not only has he retained and mentioned every important fact in the lives of the Holy Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and other saintly personalities, which are of lessons to men, but also discussed in brought outline some other important matters. It is hoped that with Allah's grace, those persons who are occupied and busy at all times, will be able to derive adequate benefit from this work.

The great effort of Sayed Tanzeem Hussain in this old age of his is really something praiseworthy. May Allah reward him well for this great effort.

Qari Sayed Rasheedul-Hasan Hussainy Nadwi

Imam and Khateeb

Jama Masjid, New Town

Allamah Binori Town, Karachi

P5 Muharram, 1308 Hijri

Publisher's Foreword

The respected personality of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy is one of the most eminent Ulama of the Indo-Pak Sub-Continent. His most approved and well-known book, *Qasasul-Qur'ān* is considered to be a unique publication on this subject. The point that distinguishes it from other similar books is the fact that after every story, Maulana has made use of deep thought and reflection to present to the readers the lessons and points of guidance from the related episodes. Thus for the teachers and lecturers at *Deeni Madressas* and for preachers in mosques and students of deen the study and perusal of this book is of utmost benefit.

The original book appeared in four volumes with over 1800 pages of subject matter. Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version there of in only 600 pages and this has been met with a verdict of approval from all academic circles, especially by virtue of the fact that he has fulfilled one of the most pressing needs of the time and by leaving aside unimportant discussions have given the busy and occupied ones also a chance to benefit from these work. May Allah reward him well.

Author's Foreword

All praise be to Allah who has guided us with the Holy Book and revealed to us the Qur'ān in a clear Arabic language and in it. He related the best of stories as an admonition and a reminder for the believers. And May peace and blessings be upon the Most truthful and trustworthy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the messenger of Allah and seal of all the Prophets and upon his offspring, and companions who were all of them guiding stars for all the righteous ones.

Among the inimitable ways in which Allah has chosen for the sake of the guidance of men, is this that attention is drawn to the good and bad deeds of nations and the resultant fruits of such deeds of which they are reminded so that those deeds may be a lesson for men. For this reason those stories are not being related in a style as is generally done in history. The major aim is to convey the truth and to invite to Allah and with this in mind attention is only drawn to those aspects which furthers this objective. For this reason there is constant repetition so that these events can sink into the hearts and minds of listeners and they become attentive towards them. This sinking in and attentiveness can only be achieved if the same event is repeated in various ways and styles whereby sleeping faculties are woken up.

The Qur'ānic stories and events deal mostly with previous nations and the Messengers of Allah (*Alaihimus*

Salām) who were sent to them and bit by bit other matters also become included there-in, mostly dealing with the arguments over good and bad and the battles between the friends of Allah and the friends of *Shaitan*, which in itself proves to be a great lesson and admonishment for me.

But, leaving others aside, there are today so few Muslims who derive benefit from Allah's last and perfect law-book, the Qur'ān, to fill our hearts with *Iman* and *Yaqeen*. After all it is Allah's law and we are commanded to implement its orders in our lives, Moreover we are required to ponder over its meanings as this Qur'ān is the means forwards acquiring success and salvation in both this world and the here after.

At the time of the Revelation of the Qur'ān, the Messenger of Allah became so distressed and defected at the enmity and opposition of the polytheists that he raised this complaint to Allah:

(5:25—30)

However, in this 15th century, if we should examine our hearts, we will find that in spite of our claims to be Muslims and believing the Qur'ān to be the word of Allah, how few are who have made this word of Allah the pattern for their lives and the model on which to base their lives, who read and recited with this aim in mind?

It was my aim, seeing this condition of my people and myself, to translate this great source of admonition into Urdu so that by presenting the translated version, the hearts of people will automatically become drawn to the original i.e., the Qur'ān and thereby acquire everlasting happiness.

In spite of my simple style of writing, care has been taken to confine myself to a few special points.

- (a) In this book the basis for all the stories is the Holy Qur'ān and the authentic *Hadith* and these have been further elucidated with historical facts.
- (b) Where there appears any contradiction or differences in the stories as told in the old testament and the Qur'ān, then with clear arguments an effort has been made either to reconcile the versions or with clear arguments to prove the truth as is expounded in the Qur'ān.
- (c) An effort has been made to point out the nonsensical Israili stories and where there have been nonsensical objections from enemies, these have in the light of the true facts been made clear for what they are.
- (d) In some special places there have been introduced some discussions on matters of disputes in *Tafseer* and *Hadith* and after discussing these the views of the saintly elders have been mentioned as a solution.
- (e) The facts concerning every Prophet ﷺ and in which chapter of the Qur'ān they are mentioned, has been gathered in one place.
- (f) Lastly, together with all the above points, a special heading of "Results and lessons", is introduced, giving the actual objective of this book and its main purpose viz., admonition and warning. Special attention is drawn to this aspect.

Servant of the Millat

Muhammad Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy

22 Rajab, 1360 Hijri

Translator's Foreword

For me as the translator of this book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman is a great honour. Throughout my student days in Darul Uloom Deoband in India, Maulana Hifzur Rahman or as we know him then as the *Mujahid-e-Millat* was one of the most respected leaders of the Muslim community. We used to flock to listen to his most interesting lectures. And as the general secretary of the *Jamiatul-Ulama*, and a M.P. he was also a great 'Alim (scholar) as can be gauged from this book *Qasasul Ambiya* (Tales of the Prophets) which entailed great research. I can remember whenever the students were confronted with any problem in the lives of any of the prophets, they always took refuge in Maulana's book for answers. I took upon it as a great honour in being in some small manner associated with Maulana's scholarship, even though this is an abridged version of the original book. But I must also state that I found great difficulty in translating this book because of the exceptionally high quality of the Urdu language used in the book.

I hope that the English translation of Maulana Hifzur Rahman's scholarly work will also be of great benefit to the English-speaking people. I just hope that I have been able to do justice to the original thoughts of the author.

Yusuf Karaan
Strand, South Africa